

# Refund Policy

Eligibility, authority and customer recovery

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| Applies to            | Waterfront, Old Town and North Park |

## Fictional material for AI assistant testing

All business details, policies, amounts, roles, contacts and examples in this document were invented for document extraction, chunking, retrieval and question-answering tests. They do not represent a real employer or an adopted legal, food-safety or consumer policy.

This PDF contains selectable text, numbered policy sections, realistic exceptions and cross-document references. Use the current versions of all three documents together.

# Contents and document map

Find the governing section before applying a threshold or exception. Each section begins on a new page so retrieved answers can cite both the section ID and PDF page.

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## The three-document set

EH-001 Employee Handbook: scheduling, pay processes, leave, employee conduct, benefits and training.  
OM-001 Operations Manual: opening, service, cash, inventory, food handling, cleaning, closing and incidents.  
RP-001 Refund Policy: eligibility, approval authority, amounts, payment methods, cancellations and recovery records.

## Interpretation notes

A specific exception overrides a general rule only within the stated scope. Approval authority does not create eligibility. Missing facts should remain unknown: do not supply personal pay rates, local statutory requirements, supplier-specific temperatures or platform terms that are not present in the source.

All three documents share version 1.0 and the September 1, 2026 effective date. No superseded policies are included.

## RP-01

# Scope, eligibility and definitions

## Policy purpose and controlling document

This policy governs refunds, replacements, credits, cancellations, and related customer-recovery decisions for the fictional Harbor & Hearth Gelato Cafe. It applies to company-operated stores and orders paid through the company's own ordering channel. Third-party delivery orders follow the platform processing rules in RP-05. The policy owner is the regional customer experience team.

RP-001 is the controlling source for financial customer remedies. The Operations Manual supplies transaction, service, and incident workflows; the Employee Handbook supplies employee conduct and self-approval rules. A friendly apology, an employee discount, or a service-time target does not independently establish refund eligibility.

## Definitions used throughout the policy

A refund returns eligible money previously captured from the customer. A replacement or remake supplies a corrected item without collecting another payment for that item. Store credit is an approved company credit for a future purchase and is not cash. A void cancels an unpaid item or a transaction before capture. A pending card authorization is not necessarily a settled charge.

The affected-item amount is what the customer actually paid for the affected product after allocated discounts, plus applicable tax on the refunded product. It excludes unrelated items, delivery fees unless specifically eligible, and gratuities unless a separate gratuity correction is approved. Monetary approval limits use the total proposed remedy value including applicable tax and credits, not the original menu subtotal alone.

## General eligibility principles

Offer an appropriate remedy when an order is missing, incorrect, defective, not delivered through a company-controlled channel, or not fulfilled by the business. Check the request window, purchase evidence, order channel, prior remedies, and approval level. A customer may choose an eligible refund instead of a replacement; a staff member must involve someone with monetary authority to issue it.

Do not promise both a full replacement and a full refund for the same loss unless the GM documents a justified exception within their monetary authority. Correcting a separate error is not a duplicate remedy. Company approval limits never increase the amount of the customer's actual loss or authorize a fictitious transaction.

## Time conventions and dataset limits

All request windows are measured from the event specified in the relevant section and include weekends unless stated as business days. A deadline stated in hours uses elapsed hours and includes the exact boundary. A business day is Monday-Friday excluding company-observed holidays. Use the store's local time for appointments and scheduled catering.

This is invented material for retrieval testing. Any applicable mandatory consumer rights would take precedence in actual use. No jurisdiction-specific legal requirements, live platform terms, or real payment-processor guarantees are supplied in this dataset.

## RP-02

## Approval limits and exceptions

| Role                            | Maximum authority per order / case                                                                                      |
|---------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Team member                     | One immediate remake or replacement of one affected item with original menu price of \$12 or less; no monetary refunds. |
| Shift lead / assigned MOD       | Up to \$50 total monetary remedy value, including applicable tax.                                                       |
| Assistant general manager (AGM) | Up to \$150 total monetary remedy value, including applicable tax.                                                      |
| General manager (GM)            | Up to \$500 total monetary remedy value, including applicable tax.                                                      |
| Regional director               | Above \$500; also approves remedies above the GM limit.                                                                 |

### How to apply the limits

These are authorization ceilings, not automatic entitlements. Exactly \$50 is within shift-lead authority; \$50.01 requires at least an AGM. Exactly \$150 is within AGM authority; \$150.01 requires at least a GM. Exactly \$500 is within GM authority; \$500.01 requires the regional director. Count monetary refunds and issued store credit together for the same order or underlying case.

If an earlier \$30 monetary remedy has been issued and an additional \$25 is proposed for the same order, the cumulative \$55 requires AGM approval. Staff may not split one case into multiple refunds or multiple ticket numbers to remain below a limit. A related replacement must still be disclosed so the approver can prevent duplicate recovery.

### Replacement limits and immediate assistance

The team-member replacement allowance applies once per order and covers one item with an original menu price no greater than \$12. A more expensive item, multiple replacement items, or a second replacement requires MOD review. Approved replacement scope follows actual affected items; staff should not replace an entire party's order for one incorrect cup without a documented reason.

A safety-related complaint always goes to the MOD even when the amount is below a normal threshold. Prompt assistance and product isolation must not wait for refund approval. A manager may gather evidence while a higher approver decides the financial remedy.

### Policy exceptions and conflicts of interest

A GM may approve a documented exception to an ordinary request window or standard remedy restriction within the \$500 ceiling. Above that amount, the regional director must approve. A shift lead or AGM may approve an eligible standard refund within their limit but cannot independently waive a policy window. Exceptions cannot bypass payment security, platform control, duplicate-remedy prevention, or mandatory rights.

No employee may approve their own purchase adjustment or a refund that creates a personal conflict. Another qualified approver reviews it. Record the original rule, reason for the exception, actual loss, prior remedy, approver, amount, and case identifier. If the required approver is unavailable, open a case and give the customer a follow-up time rather than promise approval.

## RP-03

## Product issues and return windows

| Purchase or issue                                   | Standard request window and remedy                                                                                                                                             |
|-----------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Prepared food, scoops and drinks                    | Report within 48 hours after purchase or scheduled fulfillment, whichever is later. Wrong, missing or quality-defective items qualify for replacement or affected-item refund. |
| Sealed take-home products                           | Quality concerns: report within 14 calendar days after purchase. Change-of-mind returns are excluded because storage history is unknown.                                       |
| Nonfood merchandise                                 | Return within 30 calendar days after purchase, unused, with original packaging and proof of purchase; refund actual amount paid.                                               |
| Suspected illness, allergen event or foreign object | Report immediately when known. No routine reporting cutoff is used to refuse safety intake; escalate to MOD and GM.                                                            |

### Prepared-product expectations

Customers do not need to bring a consumed or potentially unsafe food item back to the store to report a problem. Request the order reference and a description; a photograph may help if safely available but is not an absolute requirement. Do not ask a customer to taste a disputed product again. Isolate implicated store stock under OM-06 when safety could be involved.

For a simple flavor preference change with a correctly prepared item, a same-visit courtesy replacement of one item is permitted within the role limits in RP-02. A change of mind alone does not create a monetary refund entitlement for prepared food. Missing or incorrectly prepared items are handled as service failures rather than preference changes.

### Sealed products and merchandise

A broken seal at purchase, incorrect item, or verified product defect can qualify within the sealed-product window. Product damage caused only by the customer's storage after a correctly fulfilled purchase is excluded from the standard remedy. When responsibility is uncertain, document the facts and request GM review rather than accusing the customer.

For nonfood merchandise, an item that is used or missing original packaging falls outside the ordinary change-of-mind return rule. A genuine defect is reviewed by the GM even when the standard conditions are not met. Merchandise returns use the amount paid after discounts and applicable tax, subject to RP-04.

### Safety-related remedies

The MOD opens a safety incident and a linked recovery case immediately after becoming aware of a safety complaint. The GM reviews the remedy with regional support as needed. A routine purchase window does not prevent safety intake, and a refund is not a medical judgment or admission about causation. Claims for injury or consequential losses are escalated; this dataset does not supply compensation amounts.

## RP-04

## Refund amounts, proof and settlement

### Proof of purchase and missing receipts

Accept a printed receipt, digital receipt, order confirmation, or a successful POS lookup that identifies the original transaction. For a lookup, request the store, approximate purchase date and time, approximate amount, and permitted payment reference such as the last four card digits. Never request a full card number, security code, or account password.

Without a located transaction or other verifiable purchase evidence, staff cannot issue a standard monetary refund. The GM may review alternative evidence and a courtesy replacement or store credit within their authority. A missing paper receipt alone is not grounds to deny a refund when a valid transaction can be found.

### Calculating partial and discounted refunds

Refund the actual paid value of eligible items, including tax attributable to those items using the original POS tax treatment. Allocate order-level discounts proportionally across eligible product prices as recorded by the POS. Do not refund the undiscounted menu price. Unaffected items remain charged unless the approved case explains why a broader remedy is necessary.

A refund must not exceed the captured amount less previous refunds on the applicable tender. Store credit counts as a remedy and must be checked before an additional refund. Tips are not automatically included in an item refund; an erroneous or unauthorized gratuity is reviewed as a separate billing correction under the same case approval rules.

### Tender rules

Return a card payment to its original payment method through the POS. If the original card was replaced or the account is unavailable, do not substitute cash; the GM asks the processor for the approved route. Cash purchases may be refunded in cash when verified and authorized. If sufficient cash is unavailable, arrange an approved follow-up rather than forcing the customer to accept credit.

For split tender, restore the eligible amount proportionally to the original tender amounts unless the POS requires a different documented processor allocation. Never return more to one tender than was captured on it, net of previous refunds. Gift-card-funded portions return to a gift card or approved store credit, not cash under this fictional standard policy.

### Timing and status communication

After approval and required verification, the store targets submission of the refund within one business day. Card refunds typically appear within five to ten business days after submission in this test scenario. These are separate intervals: a decision date is not a settlement date. The store provides the refund reference and submission date.

If a card refund has not appeared after ten business days from submission, the GM opens a processor trace and updates the customer. Do not issue a second refund solely because the first is not yet visible. Store credit is issued within one business day of approval and records the customer's acceptance and any stated terms.

## RP-05

## Billing errors and sales channels

### Duplicate charges and wrong amounts

Report billing errors within 30 calendar days after the transaction date for standard review. The MOD compares receipts, transaction identifiers, captured amounts, voids, and prior refunds. Two similar pending authorizations do not by themselves prove two settled charges. Where settlement is unclear, the GM requests processor confirmation.

A verified duplicate capture qualifies for return of the duplicate amount, including its associated tax or erroneous gratuity, to the original tender. The remaining valid purchase is not refunded merely because a duplicate occurred. An overcharge qualifies for the verified difference. Normal approval ceilings in RP-02 apply to the correction.

### Company ordering and pickup channels

Orders placed and paid through the company's own checkout are processed by the store using the order record, even if an outside courier performs delivery on the company's behalf. If the company accepts responsibility for delivery and the order never arrives, RP-06 governs the unfulfilled-order remedy.

Ask which checkout collected payment rather than inferring ownership from the courier's name. A delivery complaint and a store preparation complaint may require different investigations, but the customer should receive one coordinated case reference for the underlying order.

### Third-party platform orders

When a delivery platform collected payment through its own checkout, the platform processes monetary refunds under its rules. Store staff record the complaint, provide permitted order evidence, and help the customer find the platform's support route. They must not take money from the register to duplicate a platform refund.

A GM may consider a disclosed courtesy replacement for a store-caused error when the customer can safely collect it, but records any platform claim and coordinates to avoid duplicate compensation. This policy does not specify platform-specific time limits, fees, or guarantees. The assistant should not invent those terms from the company's direct-order rules.

### Disputes, fees and restricted requests

If a chargeback or payment dispute is already open, the GM coordinates with the processor before submitting a refund that could duplicate a dispute credit. Do not ask the customer to disclose banking credentials or withdraw a dispute as an informal condition of receiving help. Preserve the case evidence and communication history.

Third-party delivery fees are controlled by the platform unless the company itself collected the fee. For a company-collected delivery fee, refund it when the company failed to perform the delivery service; retain it when delivery was correctly completed and only an individual product needs a partial refund. Requests to refund another person's card to a new card or cash are refused and escalated.

## RP-06

## Catering, cancellations and no-shows

### Catering bookings and balances

A catering order is a prearranged event order accepted through the catering channel with an event date, fulfillment time, written item list, and quoted total. A 50 percent deposit confirms the booking; the remaining balance is due 48 hours before scheduled fulfillment. The written confirmation identifies the store's local time zone. Changes require written acceptance by the catering coordinator.

An approved custom order must disclose any specifically agreed nonrecoverable supplier cost before the customer pays. Without that written agreement, staff apply the standard cancellation schedule below and may not invent an extra preparation fee. A disputed custom term goes to the GM or regional director.

| Cancellation received before fulfillment  | Standard catering cancellation charge                                                       |
|-------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| At least 72 hours                         | No cancellation charge; refund payments already collected.                                  |
| At least 24 hours but fewer than 72 hours | Charge 50 percent of the quoted order total; refund any collected amount above that charge. |
| Fewer than 24 hours, or customer no-show  | Charge 100 percent of the quoted order total; no standard cancellation refund.              |

### Applying the catering schedule

Use the time the company receives the customer's cancellation, not the time a manager later reads it. Exactly 72 hours qualifies for no cancellation charge; exactly 24 hours falls into the 50 percent charge band. Refunds cannot exceed the amount actually collected. If collected funds are below a cancellation charge, the GM reviews the outstanding balance against the accepted booking terms.

A customer-requested date change is reviewed using the same cancellation bands if the original booking cannot be moved without cost. The GM may waive or reduce a charge as a documented exception within their authority. Store-caused cancellation is handled separately and does not use the customer cancellation penalty.

### Ordinary pickup orders and company failure

A direct-channel, noncatering order canceled before preparation begins receives a full refund of the collected order amount. Once preparation has begun, a voluntary change-of-mind cancellation has no standard refund; a GM may approve an exception. For a late pickup or no-show, staff document storage and disposition and may not promise indefinite holding of perishable goods.

When the business cancels an order or cannot supply the promised order, offer a full refund of the unfulfilled order and any company-collected unperformed delivery charge, or an alternative the customer accepts. If only part is unavailable, offer an affected-item refund; a full cancellation may be appropriate when the missing portion defeats the order's purpose, subject to approval. Do not apply a customer cancellation penalty to the company's own failure.

## RP-07

# Gift cards, promotions and case records

## Gift cards and store credit

Gift-card purchases are not ordinarily refundable for cash under this fictional policy. A verified duplicate or erroneous gift-card sale is reviewed by the GM and reversed through the approved system when the value has not been spent. Mandatory redemption rights, if applicable in a real setting, take precedence; this dataset does not specify local cash-redemption thresholds.

A lost gift card may be replaced only when the original purchase and remaining balance can be verified and the old card can be disabled. Store credit issued for customer recovery does not expire under this fictional policy and carries no inactivity fee. Record the issuing case and value so it cannot silently be combined with a later refund for the same loss.

## Promotions and loyalty adjustments

A promotional coupon has no cash value. For a discounted purchase, the refund is based on the paid amount allocated to the affected item. If a loyalty reward paid for the entire item, restore the redeemed reward when the system permits; do not invent a cash value for the reward. A cash-paid portion is handled under normal tender rules.

When a refund would change eligibility for a bundle promotion, use the original POS allocation rather than retroactively creating an unexpected penalty. Any unavoidable system limitation is reviewed by the GM and explained before processing. Employee-discount purchases are eligible under the same product rules, using the actual discounted amount paid.

## Minimum recovery record

Each case records case ID, received date and time, store, channel, original order ID, purchase date, affected items, actual paid amounts, complaint category, requested remedy, prior remedies, evidence reviewed, eligibility rule, decision, approver, refund or credit amount, tender, processing reference, and next action. Customer contact information is optional unless needed for follow-up.

Use standard reason labels: WRONG-ITEM, MISSING-ITEM, QUALITY, SAFETY, DUPLICATE-CHARGE, OVERCHARGE, CANCELLATION, MERCHANDISE-RETURN, and GOODWILL. Record safety details in the restricted incident system with a cross-reference. Never store full card numbers, security codes, identity-document images, or unrelated medical information in a refund case.

## Review, retention and reopening

Acknowledge ordinary cases within one business day and target an initial decision within three business days after required details arrive. A customer may ask the GM to review a decline within seven calendar days after the decision; a decision made by the GM is reviewed by regional customer experience. A late review request may still be considered for new evidence or safety concerns.

Retain recovery and refund records for 24 months after case closure, longer if subject to a hold. Restrict access to employees who need it for their role. Reopen a case when processing fails or new evidence changes the decision, preserving the prior entries and explaining the revised outcome.

## RP-08

## Worked decisions and reference index

### Example 1 - A discounted item refund

A direct order contains two products priced at \$12 and \$8, with a \$4 order-level discount. The discount allocates \$2.40 to the first product and \$1.60 to the second. The customer paid \$9.60 and \$6.40 before tax. If the first product is missing, its product refund is \$9.60 plus its original attributable tax, not \$12. See RP-04.

### Example 2 - Authority uses tax and prior remedies

An eligible refund totals \$49 before tax plus \$3.92 in original tax, or \$52.92. It requires AGM approval because the total exceeds \$50. If the order already received \$120 in monetary remedies and an additional \$35 is justified, the cumulative \$155 requires GM approval. Do not split the extra \$35 into smaller cases. See RP-02.

### Example 3 - A catering cancellation

A \$400 catering order is fully paid and scheduled for Saturday at 2:00 p.m. A cancellation received Thursday at 2:00 p.m. arrives 48 hours before fulfillment. The charge is 50 percent of \$400, or \$200, and the refund is \$200. GM approval is required. If only the \$200 deposit had been collected, no cancellation refund would remain under the same band. See RP-06.

### Example 4 - Receipt lookup and platform ownership

A customer has no paper receipt, but a permitted lookup finds the direct-store transaction and an eligible quality complaint reported 20 hours after purchase. The absence of paper does not defeat the claim. In contrast, an order paid through a delivery platform's checkout uses platform monetary processing even if store staff prepared the wrong flavor. See RP-04 and RP-05.

### Example 5 - Safety intake outside a routine window

A customer reports a possible foreign object five days after a prepared-food purchase. The ordinary 48-hour product window has passed, but staff still open a safety incident and escalate to the MOD and GM. The GM reviews the remedy; the team member does not automatically reject the report or diagnose an injury. See RP-03 and OM-06.

| Question                                  | Controlling section                           |
|-------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| Who can approve \$150.01?                 | RP-02: GM or regional director.               |
| When does the card waiting period start?  | RP-04: submission, not the initial complaint. |
| Can a team member refund a \$9 drink?     | RP-02: no monetary refund authority.          |
| What happens at exactly 72 hours?         | RP-06: no catering cancellation charge.       |
| What is a particular platform's deadline? | RP-05: not specified; check platform terms.   |